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REBECOMING: THE LATEST MODEL



A memoir, restructured

BY MK PARRISH

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A note before we start

Most books that promise to change you open with a promise and close with a worksheet. This one has no worksheet. It has a QR code, a flight of rain-dark church steps, eleven minutes I almost spend walking the other way, and (this is the part I most want you to hear) a roomful of women who became, against every prediction I ever made about my life, the great loves of it. I find the code in the parish bulletin, of all the ordinary places, a small black-and-white square tucked between the Mass times and a notice about the food pantry, advertising a women's Bible study; I scan it almost by accident, the way the important things tend to arrive, while I am looking for something else entirely. After that, nothing in my life ever sits in quite the same place again.

I want to tell you what I found on the other side of that door, because somebody told you a story about it that isn't true. They told you the door was for a certain kind of person. They told you what kind of woman walks through it, and what kind of woman doesn't, and they let you assume, without ever quite saying it, which kind you are. I believed that story for most of my life. I am writing this book to take it apart in front of you, gently, one beam at a time, and then to show you what is actually inside: a beautiful old church, friendship with no audition, love with no invoice, a way of praying that turned the lights back on in me, and a hope I had genuinely stopped believing was still in stock for someone like me.

I am a Pisces and a poet and a lifelong insomniac and, it turns out, an empath and a highly sensitive person, which together mean I feel everything at a volume the world keeps calling a malfunction. For years I am certain that if I think hard enough and stay up late enough, I can out-argue my own fear. I cannot. You do not think your way out of a feeling. You pray your way through the middle of it, and it helps, more than I can tell you, to find that someone has gone ahead, is holding the door, and has already set out a chair with your name on it.

Two of the people who told me I had a story worth telling are gone now. I am telling it anyway. This is me, finally, telling it.

PART ONE: THE QR CODE

It is raining by the time I reach the church, and I stand at the bottom of the steps for eleven minutes without going up them.

I know it is eleven because I watch each one turn over on my phone, the same small lit rectangle that carried me here, the same one that holds the whole shouting world, the way you watch a kettle you are praying will not boil. When you do not own a car, you arrive at things on foot and on time and with no armor at all. There is no idling at the curb with the heater running. No metal shell to hide inside while you quietly lose your nerve. There is only me, and the cold coming up through the thin soles of my shoes, and the gray Saturday going wet and silver around my shoulders, and a lit doorway forty feet up and to the left that might as well be set in the far wall of an ocean.

Let me put you exactly where I am, because the where of it matters. This is not some borrowed conference room with a folding sign out front. This is the parish church, my parish, a beautiful old building with a bell tower gone green at the seams and a rose window over the doors that, even unlit from the street, holds the gray light like a held breath. The stone under my feet is dark and slick and veined with rain, each step keeping its own thin sheet of water that breaks and re-forms when the wind moves over it. The handrail is beaded silver, too cold to want to touch. The brass plate beside the door has gone soft and green at its edges and bright where a hundred years of hands have worn it. Somewhere up there a candle is going. I cannot see it yet, but I will learn the smell of it in a minute and spend the rest of my life loving it. The bulletin is folding to pulp in my fist. My breath is going halfway down and stopping, the way it has been stopping for years.

I am only standing here at all because of a square of ink. A week ago, I slipped into the back of this same church for a Mass I almost talked myself out of, and on my way out I picked up the parish bulletin the way you pick up anything, to give your hands something to do. And there, tucked in between the Mass schedule and a notice about the food pantry, was a small black-and-white QR code beside three plain words: *Women's Bible*

Study. Before I could think better of it, I lifted my phone to the little square the way you might touch a stranger on the shoulder, and it opened a page with a date and a time and this address, and it asked, gently, for my name. I gave it. That was the whole of my brave act, a week early: I let a QR code in a church bulletin write my name down somewhere I could not quietly erase it later. Everything after this, the rain, the steps, the eleven minutes, is only me trying to live up to a thing my own thumb had already gone and done.

I have a speech ready. I walked the whole way over rehearsing it, a small, reasonable, beautifully constructed case for why this particular morning is not the morning. I am tired. I have a Saturday's worth of errands I could hide inside of for hours. My dog needs me, which is a lie, because Biggie has been unconscious on the good pillow since breakfast and treats my entire existence as a mild interruption to his sleep.

But underneath the speech sits the real reason, and it is wearing a costume I know by heart. It leans in close, in my own voice, the most trusted voice I have got, and it says: *you are not the kind of woman who goes to Bible study.*

And here is where I have to stop and show you the picture, because the picture is the whole problem, and I carried it for so long I forgot it was a picture at all. A certain kind of woman with a certain kind of certainty. Women who had never once lain awake at two in the morning doubting the floor of the universe. Women in a tidy row who would look at the wreckage of me and quietly, charitably, thank God they had been spared it. A panel of judges. A club I had failed to qualify for without ever once filling out the

form. I held that picture for years, fully formed, never examined, the way you can carry an opinion your entire life without ever asking where you picked it up or whether it was ever yours.

That picture is the stigma. And I want to be very clear with you, this early, about what I learned: the picture was never describing the room. It was only ever describing my fear of the room. The two have almost nothing to do with each other, and learning the difference is going to cost me eleven minutes in the rain and then save the rest of my life.

Then the rain stops pretending. It comes down all at once: fat, cold, deliberate, drumming the steps and darkening the stone two shades and running the ink on the bulletin clean off the page and into my palm in little gray rivers, and it pushes me up the steps and through the door. Partly by grace. Partly because I will not come apart on a public sidewalk like a woman in the third act of a film no one agreed to make.

And the inside of that old church takes my breath the way it has been taking the breath of frightened people since before my grandmother's grandmother. The ceiling lifts away into a vault you cannot quite see the top of. The late stained glass throws long lozenges of red and blue across the stone floor, even on a gray day, even in the rain, as though the building keeps its own private weather of color. There is the smell of beeswax and cold incense and old wood and rain coming off wool. There is a rack of votive candles burning low and gold against the dim, a little galaxy of other people's intentions, each flame a prayer somebody could not say out loud. I came ready to endure something. Instead, standing just inside the door with the water running off me, I want, with my whole sudden traitor of a heart, to stay.

And before I can second-guess a single thing, before the heavy door has even finished sighing shut behind me on its slow brass hinge, before I have wiped the rain from my eyes, she is there.

The group leader. She crosses the room toward me the way dawn crosses a field, unhurried and total, and she does not offer me a hand to shake and she does not ask my name first and she does not give me a moment to

arrange my face into something braver than it is. She simply opens both arms and folds me into a hug so complete, so unhesitating, that for one whole second I forget that I am a stranger, that I am soaked through, that I am afraid. She holds on like she has been saving this exact embrace all morning and has only just now found who it belonged to.

And she is warm. Actually warm: radiant the way a lit window is warm seen from a freezing street, the way the inside of a cupped hand is warm. Over her shoulder the candlelight seems to lean toward her, the low gold of it pooling around her hair until I half expect to find it gilded, haloed, leafed like the saints in the side chapels behind her, the ones standing patient in their niches with their chipped plaster hands open. She glows. I am not reaching for a metaphor; or I am, but it is also simply, plainly, what I see. She lights the room the way one candle lights a shrine, not by flooding it, but by giving every shadow in it somewhere gentle to go and lie down.

Angelic is the word that arrives, fully formed, and I do not bother hunting for a better one, because there is not one, and I have spent my whole life hunting for better words.

And into my wet hair, soft, like it is the simplest and most settled fact in the world, she says: *"You came. You already did it."*

You already did it.

We gather not in some grim annex but in the Lady chapel off the south transept, a circle of chairs drawn up under a statue of the Blessed Mother with her foot on the moon. There are twelve of us. A college sophomore with her sleeves pulled all the way down over her hands, her knee going under the chair. A woman much further along, silver-haired and still as a held breath, who looks as though she has buried a couple of husbands and kept most of their secrets out of plain good manners. Women in the middle, like me, composed on the outside, immaculate, carrying things on the inside we have never once said out loud to anyone living.

And no one makes it strange. That is the second miracle of the morning, and I have learned since not to rank my miracles by size. The woman who settles in beside me slides her own copy of the book across to me, open,

and I look down and the margins are crowded. Underlines. Question marks. Whole sentences boxed and starred and argued with in three different colors of ink, the pages soft and furred at the corners from being turned and turned. She does not slide me a clean book. She slides me her mess. And that, it turns out, is the real invitation: not *here is the answer,* but *here is how unfinished I still am; come be unfinished beside me.*

I think about the prodigal son the whole way home, in a way I have not in years. Everyone remembers the homecoming, the robe, the ring, the fattened calf, the father hiking up his good clothes to run flat-out down the road. But I keep landing on the part that comes first, the part nobody paints. The son is still a long way off. Still in the mud. Still rank with pig. He has not been forgiven yet and has no idea how any of it will land, and he gets up anyway, and turns toward home, and starts to walk. *While he was still a long way off,* the gospel says, *his father saw him and was filled with compassion; he ran to him and threw his arms around him.* Still a long way off. The father was already running before the boy had a single word out.

There is a name for that turn. The old Greek for it is *metanoia,* and we usually translate it as *repentance,* which sounds like sackcloth and apology. But it does not mean groveling. It means, almost literally, *to turn the mind around.* To be walking one direction and to stop, and to turn, and to start walking the other. That is it. That is the whole of it. Not arrival. Not certainty. Just the turn, and a Father already running.

There is an invitation I had heard quoted my whole life, printed on tote bags and coffee mugs and the backs of parish bulletins, worn so smooth by overuse that I had long ago stopped hearing it as actual words. *Come to me, all you who are weary and are carrying heavy burdens, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.* Come to me, all you who are weary. Not: come to me, all you who have it together. Not: come to me once you have lost the weight and mended the marriage and silenced the two-in-the-morning voice and assembled yourself into the right kind of woman. Come weary. Come

carrying. Come exactly as heavy as you actually are. I had spent my entire life certain the invitation had a dress code I could never meet, and it turns out the only thing required at that door was the one thing I had always had in abundance. I was tired. I was carrying something far too heavy. And I had, at last, in the rain, come.

Nobody puts that part in stained glass. The turning around. The eleven minutes at the bottom of the steps. The thumb hovering over a small square of black and white. The stranger's arms closing around you before you have even said your name.

I have not arrived anywhere yet. I have only turned around and started walking home. It is going to take me a long time, most of this book, to understand that the turn is the thing. That it was always the thing. That she was right, there in the doorway, with the rain still running off me onto her shoulder: I already did it.

PART TWO: THE HALLWAY

Let me back up and show you who walked up those steps, because you should know what kind of life it was that the rain pushed me out of.

By day I am good at marketing, and I have been for years. I build the campaign that lands. I write the words a chief executive says on a stage as though they had always lived in his own mouth. I can take a quarter of pipeline panic and turn it into a plan that holds, and I can walk into a room of executives and know, inside a minute, exactly what each of them is most afraid of. None of that is the problem. I want to say that plainly, because the easy version of this story is the one where the career is the villain, and that is not true and it would be ungrateful besides. The work is good. I am good at it.

The problem is quieter, and it does not fit on a résumé. There is a particular ache to spending your one wild ration of daylight on work that does not match the size of what you carry. A low, daily, almost inaudible grief, the kind you can live inside for years without ever naming, of feeling your real life running in a browser tab you can hear but cannot quite click over to. I build the brand and the demand and the beautiful deck. The workday finally closes its laptop. And the poet I have been since I was a girl is still sitting in the corner with her arms crossed, waiting, the way a child waits in a coat by the door for a trip that keeps getting postponed.

Here is the image that came to me, once, and would not leave. I am in a hallway. Not a room. A hallway is a place you pass through on the way to the place you actually live, and somewhere along the line I had mistaken the passage for the destination and unpacked my whole self in it. I had hung pictures in the hallway. I had learned to sleep standing up in the hallway. And hallways, however long, however well-lit, however lined with

the framed evidence of a competent life, are not where anyone is meant to live. You can spend a decade in one and call it a career. I nearly spent more.

I want to hold two true things in one open hand here, because the hallway is not the whole story. I am also proud. Proud of what I built out of not very much. Proud of the rooms I clawed my way into without an invitation, in heels, on the train, with no car and no cushion and no one to call if it all went sideways. But if I am honest all the way to the bottom, I am prouder of the obstacles than of the wins. Anyone can be proud of a clean win on a good day with the wind at their back. I am proud of the comebacks. I am proud of the unwitnessed version of me who kept going when going forward was the only square left on the board, and even that felt like more than I had been given the strength for.

And still. A hallway is a hallway. There is a Scripture I had read a hundred times and never once let land, the one where Martha is busy and anxious and running the whole house and resentful of her sister Mary, who is just sitting there at the Lord's feet doing nothing useful at all. And he says, so gently it must have stung, *Martha, Martha, you are worried and distracted by many things; only one thing is necessary, and Mary has chosen the better part.* I was Martha. I was the most accomplished Martha you ever met. I had optimized my anxiety into a personal brand. I had a whole self built out of being busy and being needed and being, above all, fine. And being fine was the finest work I ever did. It was also a hallway with very good lighting, and I was starving in it, and I had been starving so long I had stopped recognizing the feeling as hunger.

There is a parable I had somehow managed never to hear, though I had been living inside it for a decade. A rich man's land produces so abundantly that he runs clean out of room to store it all, and he says to himself, in deep and reasonable satisfaction, *I will tear down my barns and build bigger ones, and there I will store all my grain and my goods, and I will say to my soul, soul, you have ample goods laid up for many years; relax, eat, drink, be merry.* And God says to him, *you fool. This very night your life is*

being demanded of you, and the things you have prepared, whose will they be? |

had built bigger barns. I had a whole life of bigger barns, beautifully organized, climate-controlled, immaculately labeled, and I had been saying to my soul, in effect, just hang on, just achieve a little more, just get the next thing built and then, then, you can finally live. The Preacher in Ecclesiastes had my number too, the man who had everything and went looking through every bit of it for the meaning underneath and came back up holding fog: *vanity of vanities, all is vanity, a chasing after wind.* And underneath even that, all along, there is a promise I simply did not believe applied to a woman like me, the one God speaks through Jeremiah to a people in exile, far from home, certain it is all finished: *for I know the plans I have for you, plans for your welfare and not for harm, to give you a future and a hope.* A future and a hope. I had a five-year plan and a content calendar and a hallway hung with the framed evidence of a competent life, and not, if you had stopped me on the street that gray morning and asked me honestly, a single future or hope I could actually feel.

That is the woman the rain pushed up the steps. Not a woman at the bottom. A woman at the top, by every visible measure, who could not have told you, that gray Saturday morning, the last time she had felt the better part of anything.

PART THREE: WHAT FEAR COSTS

Before I tell you what fear cost me, I have to tell you about the instrument it played on, because they are not the same thing.

I am an empath. I am, in the clinical language I only found in my thirties and wept a little to find, a highly sensitive person, an HSP, which sounds like a delicate diagnosis and is actually closer to a different kind of nervous system entirely. The term is not poetry; it is research. The psychologist Dr. Elaine Aron gave it a name in the nineties and a body of study underneath it: a real and measurable trait, found in something like one in five people, a brain that processes everything more deeply and feels everything more keenly and gets overwhelmed more easily for the simple reason that it is taking in more. I do not have skin so much as a screen door. The world comes straight through. I feel everything at a volume the world keeps calling a malfunction, and for most of my life I believed them, and tried, like turning down a stereo, to find the knob. There is no knob. I looked for years.

Let me show you what that actually means, on an ordinary day, because the words *empath* and *sensitive* have been worn so smooth they have stopped meaning anything. It means I can walk into a room and know, before a single word is spoken, that two people in it had a fight in the car. It means a stranger's grief three seats down on the train arrives in my own chest as a weight, real and physical, and I carry it home not knowing whose it is. It means a harsh light, a wool tag, a raised voice, a violent scene on a screen across a restaurant; these do not bother me the way they bother other people; they bruise me, the way a thumb bruises soft fruit. It means I cry at commercials and at the kindness of waiters and at the particular way late light falls across a kitchen floor, and that I have spent a great deal of energy, in a great many rooms, making sure no one ever saw me do it.

The philosophers and the saints, naturally, got there centuries before the psychologists, and I went looking for them too, the way I always do, three colors of ink at the ready. Edith Stein (who wrote her entire doctoral dissertation on the problem of empathy, *Einfühlung*, the act of feeling your way into another person) argued that this was not sentiment but a genuine form of knowledge, a real bridge across to another consciousness, and then she lived the argument all the way to its end: she became a Carmelite nun and, eventually, a saint, and died at Auschwitz, having decided that feeling-with was holy enough to die inside of. Walt Whitman put the empath's creed in one unbearable line: *I do not ask the wounded person how he feels, I myself become the wounded person.* I read it at twenty and thought, oh, that is not a poem, that is a medical chart, that is me on the train. And Simone Weil, who I love most and understand least, wrote that attention, taken to its very highest degree, is the same thing as prayer: that to give someone your full, undefended attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity there is. I read them all. I underlined them in three colors of ink, and I can report, after years of research, that knowing your sensitivity is a named trait studied by psychologists and praised by saints and sung by poets does precisely nothing, on a Tuesday, to make the train quieter. But it does something else, slower, that I will get to.

Because here is the cost, the one that ran underneath everything. For most of my life I was told, gently, by people who loved me, and not so gently by people who did not, to toughen up. To stop taking things so personally. To grow thicker skin, as though skin were the problem and not the gift. So I built the armor myself, plate by plate, and I called the armor *being fine*, and I learned to perform a calm I never once felt. And the feeling I refused at the surface did not go anywhere. It went down, into the body. An empath who is taught to be ashamed of her own wiring does not become less sensitive. She just becomes sensitive in secret, and exhausted, and alone with the volume turned all the way up and nobody allowed to hear it.

It takes me a shamefully long time to find the verse that somebody should have pressed into the hands of a child like me before I could even read it for myself. The psalmist, three thousand years before anyone thought to

coin the term *highly sensitive*, writes: *I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made; wonderful are your works, and my soul knows it very well.*

Fearfully and wonderfully. Not defectively. Not too much. Made, on purpose, with evident care, by someone who does not make mistakes and did not, it turns out, make one with me. And the same psalm says he knit me together in my mother's womb, that he has searched me and known me, that he knows when I sit down and when I rise up and discerns my thoughts from far away, that there is not a word on my tongue but he knows it altogether. A God who already feels everything I feel, at a volume that makes my volume look like a whisper from the next room, and who looks at the whole overwhelming apparatus of it and calls it good. And Paul writes to Timothy, who seems to have been a tender and easily frightened soul himself, the line I now keep where my eyes will land on it daily: *for God did not give us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind.*

Power, and love, and a sound mind. The exact three things I had been taught all my life that my sensitivity disqualified me from. It turns out the wiring I had spent decades apologizing for was never the spirit of fear at all. The fear was a separate thing entirely, a thing that moved in later, on top of the gift, uninvited, and then did the most cunning thing a tenant can do: it convinced me the house itself was the problem, so that it would never once occur to me to change the locks.

And that secret sensitivity is exactly where fear moves in and signs a lease.

For as long as I can remember, fear and I share an apartment. It never pays rent and somehow always controls the thermostat. I meet it most nights around two in the morning, when the place has gone quiet and ticking and I am the only one awake to keep it company. And here is the trick of it, the thing that keeps it in business: it never once shows up looking like fear. It comes dressed as being responsible. As being realistic. As simply not getting my hopes up, so they cannot be dashed later. It wears the good sober suit of maturity, and for years I mistake it for wisdom, when underneath the suit it is only ever a small shrieking animal absolutely certain that I am about to die.

It takes me a long time, I am still, some mornings, working this out, to understand that I am not afraid of any one nameable thing. I am afraid of existing, and existing turns out to be a fear with a thousand outfits. There is the fear of being annihilated, of the lights going out mid-sentence. There is its exact opposite, the fear of continuing, of all these years stacked ahead of me like dishes piled to the ceiling. There is the fear of being known, of letting one person see the unedited me and watching them reach quietly for their coat, and its cruel twin, the fear of never being known at all, of moving through my one and only life as a rumor of myself. Kierkegaard calls freedom a kind of dizziness, the vertigo you feel at the cliff-edge of everything you might still become. Jung says the thing you are most afraid to turn and look at is, almost always, the exact thing you most need to pick up and carry home. Augustine, fifteen centuries ago, writes the truest sentence about anxiety I have ever found: *our heart is restless until it rests in You.* Restless. Like a body that cannot get comfortable in any position in the bed.

Here is the part that still makes me laugh, the kind of laugh that loosens something stuck in the chest. The single most repeated instruction in the entire Bible is some version of *do not be afraid.* People like to say it lands three hundred and sixty-five times, one for every day of the year, and I suspect whoever first counted was also avoiding something, but the point holds, and it floors me every time. The most frequent thing the divine ever bothers to say to us is not *behave.* It is not *believe the correct things in the correct order.* It is closer to: *easy. Breathe. I have got this one.*

We did not take the note. We built the evening news. Then the push notification. Then the comment section, where fear is no longer a roommate but a public utility, piped into every hand on every train.

I think most about the parable of the talents, because it is the one that finally caught me in the act. A man going on a journey hands his servants his wealth to keep, one of them a single talent, a fortune in its day. And that last servant, the frightened one, does not lose the money or gamble it away. He does something worse and quieter and far more familiar. He buries it. He digs a hole in the ground and hides the treasure he was given,

and when the master comes home and asks for an account, the servant says the truest, saddest sentence in the whole story: *I was afraid, and I went and hid what was yours in the ground. Here, you have what is yours.* He was not punished for failing. He was undone for burying. For taking the one wild gift he was handed and putting it in the dirt where it could not embarrass him or cost him anything or be lost. I read that and I went cold, because I knew exactly where my talent was. It was a poet, in a hallway, with her arms crossed, buried under a decade of being fine.

That is what fear does, in the end. It does not always look like running. Sometimes it looks like burying. Sometimes it looks like Peter, who actually got out of the boat and walked on the water toward the Lord, genuinely walked, until he looked down and saw the wind and the waves and remembered to be afraid, and the second he was more impressed by the storm than by the One who called him out onto it, he began to sink. *You of little faith,* Jesus says, reaching down and catching him by the wrist, *why did you doubt?* Not angry. Almost amused. The hand was always right there. Peter only had to stop staring at the water long enough to take it.

And the burying has a price, and the price is not abstract. There is a season I am not okay in a way that leaves metaphor behind and moves straight into the flesh. The fear, refused at the mouth, finds another way out. It comes out as the insomnia: the long ticking hours after two, the streetlight laid in a bar across the ceiling. It comes out as a chest that will not unclench, a breath that only ever makes it halfway down. It comes out as a gray film laid over everything I used to love, the strange flat sensation of watching my own life through a window someone painted shut from the outside. The mind sends its unpaid bills straight down to the body, and the body (loyal, uncomplaining, a little foolish in its devotion) always, always pays. It keeps every single receipt.

I did not know yet that being fine was about to be made obsolete by twelve women and a circle of chairs. I did not know yet that the cure for being alone with the volume was simply, finally, to let someone else into

the room while it played. I did not know yet that there was a hand in the water the whole time, and that all I had to do, eventually, was stop staring at the storm long enough to take it.

PART FOUR: THE TURNING POINT

This is the part I had backward for so long. And having it backward is exactly what nearly keeps me out on that sidewalk for good.

When Lazarus comes out of the tomb, there is a detail I miss for years. He comes out alive, and still wrapped, head to foot, in the grave clothes. Still bound. Still trailing the linen of the place he just left, still smelling of it, blinking in light he had given up on. And the instruction Jesus gives is not *wonderful, you are breathing, sort the rest out yourself.* The instruction, spoken to the ordinary people standing right there in the daylight, the friends, the family, the neighbors, is this: *unbind him, and let him go.*

Sit with the division of labor in that for a second, because it rearranged my whole life. The miracle got him out of the grave. The people who loved him got him out of the wrappings. He could not, for all the resurrection in the world, unwind himself. Somebody had to come close, close enough to smell the tomb, and do it with their own hands. I had always thought reaching for help was the white flag, the gesture you make once you have conclusively failed at being strong. It is the opposite. It is the second half of the resurrection, the part where the people who love you crowd in close and begin, with their own warm hands, to unwind the linen. I am not ashamed of needing that anymore. It might be the truest thing I know.

And here is where I get to tell you the good part. Here is where I get to tell you what I actually walked into, because the stigma spends so much breath on what it imagines is inside that room and not one word on the truth of it.

It is called *Walking with Purpose,* and it is simpler than anything I had braced for. There is no stage. No expert. No one performing certainty down at us from a height. There is a circle of chairs and a book and two hours

and the Blessed Mother watching over the whole thing from her niche on the wall. We take a chapter at a time, one for each Saturday, and we talk about it the way women talk when nobody is keeping score: slowly, honestly, doubling back, comparing our maps of the same hard country, admitting where the map went blank. It is never really about the verses, though we read them and come to love them. It is about twelve women telling the truth in a warm and holy room.

And what I got from those Saturdays is the thing I most want to put in your hands, because it is the thing I had given up on. I got friends. Not acquaintances, not pleasant churchy contacts: friends, the real and durable kind, the kind I genuinely believed had stopped being issued to women my age. My phone, which for years had been a delivery system for dread, started lighting up midweek for an entirely new reason: a thread that never quite goes quiet, a casserole of prayer requests and small hard-won victories and somebody's kid's good news and somebody else's bad scan and a photo of a sunrise somebody pulled over on the highway to catch. Someone texts *thinking of you, praying for you* on a Tuesday for no reason at all and means it. We learn each other's hard anniversaries and we show up for them. We sit in hospital parking lots. We stand in the church lot after the session has long ended, coats on, breath fogging, and talk for another hour because none of us wants to be the first to leave. I came for a Bible study. I stayed because I had, without quite noticing the moment it happened, fallen in love with a dozen people.

That is the word I kept circling and finally just set down on the table where we could both look at it: love. Not the abstract kind from the greeting cards. The specific kind. Acceptance with no audition. Encouragement with no invoice. The plain, almost unbearable mercy of being believed the first time. Being handed not a verdict but a chair. I had filed Bible study under judgment, under brittle certainty, under a kind of airless, lemon-scented, performed goodness. What I found was the photographic negative of every bit of it: the least judgmental room I have ever sat in, full of women who lead with their doubt instead of their answers, who hand you their messy

margins instead of their conclusions, who love you while you are still wrapped head to foot in the linen and do not wait for you to be presentable first.

I think often now of what he says to his own friends on the last night, before everything comes apart. *I do not call you servants any longer,* he tells them, *because the servant does not know what the master is doing; but I have called you friends.* Friends. Of all the words the Lord of the universe had available to him for the people closest to his heart, he reaches past every grander and more theological one and chooses the plain one I had quietly given up on. And then he says the thing I now believe is the entire reason a circle of folding chairs can save a life: *no one has greater love than this, than to lay down one's life for one's friends.* I had assumed friendship at my age would be, at the very best, logistics: a calendar negotiated between tired women, a dinner rescheduled three times and finally cancelled. What I found in that room was the other thing, the laid-down-life kind, the kind that sits in a hospital parking lot at midnight, the kind that texts *praying for you* on a Tuesday for no reason at all, the kind he was talking about with the cross already in view. The friendship was never a fringe benefit of the faith. The friendship *was* the faith, walking around in a dozen ordinary, unremarkable, irreplaceable faces.

And this is the mission, so let me say it straight to you, reader to reader, because it is the reason I am writing at all: the stigma is a lie, and it is a lie that keeps people out in the rain. It kept me out for years. It is, right now, this minute, keeping somebody you know standing at the bottom of their own set of steps, rehearsing their own reasonable speech, certain they are the wrong kind of person for a room that has a chair open for them specifically, a room full of exactly the friendship and the faith and the welcome they have privately, achingly, given up on. The lie is not harmless. It costs people the precise thing I almost lost. If this book does one thing, let it walk down the steps to whoever is standing there, take them by the cold hand, and tell them the truth about what is inside: it is warmer than you think, and you are wanted there, and you are already late for people who will love you.

But the thing I least expected, the thing I want to dwell on, because it is the whole turn of my life, is what all that love did to me. It brought me back. I have to use the plain word: reinvigorated. I was a gray, flat, painted-shut version of myself when I climbed those steps, running on the fumes of fine, and somewhere across those Saturdays the color came back into the world the way it comes back into your hands after you have been out too long in the cold: that hot, almost painful return of feeling. I started sleeping again, whole nights, the two-in-the-morning shift finally relieved of its lone watchwoman. I started laughing in that room, the real kind that bends you over your knees. And (this is the one that undoes me) I started writing again. The poet I had locked in the corner with her arms crossed got up and came back to the desk, dug the talent out of the ground and brushed off the dirt, because for the first time in years I had something other than fear to report from. You cannot pour from gray. These women un-grayed me. They handed my own life back to me with the lights on.

It took me most of my life to learn the difference between faith and certainty. I had always treated them as one thing, faith as a destination you finally reach and plant a flag on and get to feel quietly superior about. But certainty is not faith. **Certainty is just fear in a better coat.** Faith is what you do while your hands are still shaking. Faith is walking toward the thing you cannot yet see and trusting the floor to come up and meet your foot in the dark, which is, when you think about it, exactly what Peter did until he stopped. *Now faith,* the letter to the Hebrews says, *is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen.* Not the proof of things seen. The conviction of things not seen. I learn that in a circle of folding chairs, from women who have far more reason than I do to be sure of everything, and who have decided, instead, to keep showing up unsure, together, on purpose. *If you have faith the size of a mustard seed,* the Lord says, *you will say to this mountain, move from here to there, and it will move.* A seed so small you could lose it in the lines of your own palm. For years I hear that as a low bar set out of pity. Now I think it is the most generous arithmetic in the world. You do not need a mountain of belief. You need a crumb. I had a crumb. The women had a warm room and a circle with

exactly one seat still open and the patience to wait while I found it. Grace, I am learning, never once asks for my qualifications. It never even glances at the form.

This is where faith stops being a feeling and turns into a paradox, the truest, hardest thing those women teach me. It is, at the very same time, the easiest and the most impossible thing a person can hold. Easy, because a crumb will do, because the entire entry fee is that you turn around. And impossible, daily impossible, because of what it asks next. It asks me to surrender. All the way down. I used to use that word as if it were soft, a spa word, a candle scent. It is not soft. Surrender means prying my own white knuckles, one finger at a time, off a wheel I have gripped since I was small, and trusting something higher and wiser and far less anxious than me to drive. I am a rank beginner at it, clumsy, grabbing the wheel back out of plain animal habit every ten minutes. But there is a prayer the women taught me, four small words, and I will get to where I learned to mean them. For now it is enough to say that they are the hardest four words in any language, and the most freeing, and that the first person ever to say them perfectly was a teenage girl in Nazareth, and her answer to the whole terrifying invitation of her life is the spine of the next two chapters.

PART FIVE: TEACH ME TO PRAY

I did not know how to pray. I want to confess that plainly, because I think it is the secret shame of half the people reading this, the ones raised inside the faith as much as the ones who came to it late. I knew the words. I had the choreography of a Catholic-school girl in a pleated plaid skirt, the words to the prayers worn so smooth in my mouth I could say them without hearing a single one. When to stand, when to kneel, when to murmur the response, when to cross myself in one unthinking motion. But knowing the choreography is not the same as having the relationship, and for most of my life my prayer, when I prayed at all, was a kind of emergency flare, fired up into the dark only when the plane was going down, addressed to a management I was not at all sure was staffed.

The women taught me something better. They taught me that prayer is not a flare. It is a practice. It is, of all the unglamorous things, a discipline, and the discipline is the doorway to the intimacy, the way scales are the doorway to the music. The disciples, who walked with him daily and watched him do the impossible, never once asked him to teach them to preach, or to heal, or to multiply the loaves. They watched him slip away before dawn to pray, again and again, and the one thing they finally asked was, *Lord, teach us to pray.* And he did not hand them a feeling. He handed them words. *Our Father.* He gave them a script, because he knew that on the days you have no feeling left, the script will carry you, and the feeling, if it is coming, will catch up.

So I learned the words on purpose, the way I once learned ad copy, except these were trying to save my life. I learned that to pray without ceasing, as Paul says, does not mean to kneel without ceasing; it means to let a current run under the whole day, a continuous low conversation with the One I have come to call, privately, the one who loves us most. That is my

name for him. Not the judge of my childhood picture, not the management I fired flares at. The one who loves us most. I tried it on like a coat I was not sure I was allowed to wear, and it fit, and I have not taken it off since.

And then the women taught me the novenas, and the novenas are where the discipline got its teeth. Nine days. You pray the same prayer, with the same intention, for nine days running, named for the nine days the apostles and the Blessed Mother spent together in the upper room between the Ascension and Pentecost, waiting, praying, not yet knowing what was coming, only that they had been told to wait for it. Nine days is a long time for a woman who fires flares. Nine days asks you to come back to the same hope when nothing has changed on day three, and nothing has changed on day six, and you are still asking on day eight with no evidence at all, which is, I came to understand, the entire point. *Pray always and do not lose heart.* Jesus says, and then tells the story of the widow, the one who has been wronged and has no power and no standing and no one to advocate for her, who goes to the unjust judge and asks, and is refused, and comes back and asks, and is refused, and comes back and asks, and comes back, and comes back, until the judge gives her justice for no other reason than that she would not stop coming. That is the novena. That is the persistent widow with a calendar. You come back, and you come back, and you come back, and somewhere in the coming back, even before the answer, the asking changes you.

I prayed the novena to Saint Jude, the patron of hopeless and lost causes, which is exactly what I had decided I was. I prayed the Divine Mercy chaplet that Saint Faustina gave us, with its small unbearable refrain, *Jesus, I trust in You,* which is just the four hardest words of surrender wearing their Sunday clothes. I learned the Memorare, that old cry to the Blessed Mother that Saint Bernard so loved, the one that begins *Remember, O most gracious Virgin Mary, that never was it known that anyone who fled to your protection was left unaided,* and I clung to that line, never was it known, like a railing on dark stairs. I learned from the saints that you do not have to feel holy to be at prayer. Saint Thérèse of Lisieux, the Little Flower, gave us the Little Way, the radical idea that you do not become a saint by doing

great things but by doing small things with great love, that a sink full of dishes offered up is as good as a cathedral, which is a gospel for a woman drowning in the ordinary. Saint Teresa of Ávila left a scrap of paper in her breviary that said, in essence, *let nothing disturb you, let nothing frighten you; all things pass; God alone is enough,* and I taped my own version of that to my own mirror. And Padre Pio, who suffered more than I will ever be asked to, distilled the entire architecture of trust into five words: *Pray, hope, and do not worry.* In that order. Pray first. Hope second. And the worrying, which I had treated as a full-time job with excellent benefits, demoted at last to the thing you simply do not do.

And the women teach me the thing that finally takes the whole crushing weight off, the thing that lets a person who is terrified of getting it wrong begin to pray at all. You do not have to be any good at it. *Likewise the Spirit helps us in our weakness,* Paul writes, *for we do not know how to pray as we ought, but the Spirit himself intercedes for us with sighs too deep for words.* Sighs too deep for words. On the nights when I have no words, when all I can manage is a kind of wordless ache aimed up at the ceiling in the dark, that ache is not a failed prayer, not a prayer that did not qualify. It is the truest kind there is, and Someone is already bent over it, translating. Paul tells the Philippians, from a prison cell of all the unlikely pulpits, *do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God, and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds.* A peace that surpasses understanding was always going to be the only kind that could reach a woman who had tried, for forty years, to understand her own way out of everything. And the psalm puts the whole impossible assignment in four words: *be still, and know that I am God.* Be still. Four words of instruction for an over-functioning mind, and the single hardest thing anyone has ever asked of me. Stop building barns. Stop staring at the storm. Stop rehearsing the speech at the bottom of the steps. Be still, and know.

What I discovered, on the far side of all that repetition, is the thing nobody warns you about prayer, the thing that sounds like a platitude until it happens to your own body in the dark: the asking stops being about getting. You go in to change God's mind and you come out with yours changed instead. *Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and the door will be opened,* and I had always heard that as a vending machine, a transaction, insert prayer, receive outcome. But the deepest thing he ever said about prayer, he said about the manner of it: *when you pray, go into your room, and shut the door, and pray to your Father who is in secret.* Into your room. Shut the door. It is the most intimate instruction in all of Scripture, and it is not about results at all. It is about a Father in the secret place who is already there, already waiting, who knows what you need before you ask, who wants, more than the answer, simply the company. I went in, all those mornings, to get something fixed. I stayed because I was no longer alone in the room. The volume that the whole world had called a malfunction turned out to be, of all things, an antenna, and prayer was the frequency, and the one who loves us most had been broadcasting on it the entire time I was telling myself to grow thicker skin.

PART SIX: THE LIVING WORD

For most of my life the Bible is a closed object. Not closed as in shut; closed as in sealed, the way a door you have never once tried can come, over the years, to feel like a wall. I think of it, on the rare occasions I think of it at all, as a kind of heirloom furniture: handsome, heavy, clearly important to people I respect, and absolutely not for sitting on. I am afraid of it the way I am afraid of the room, and for the very same reason. I am certain it was written for someone more qualified, someone who will not misread it, someone who will not drag her whole messy modern life across its pages and get the holy thing wrong.

What the Saturdays undo, slowly, is exactly that. Because the first thing I learn in that circle of chairs is that nobody there is reading it to win. We read it the way you read a letter from someone who loves you and has been gone a long time: slowly, twice, out loud, stopping on the lines that catch. And the verse that finally breaks the seal for me, the one that turns the heirloom back into something with a pulse, is from the letter to the Hebrews: *the word of God is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing until it divides soul from spirit, and discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart.* Living. Active. Not a museum piece under glass with a little rope in front of it. A blade that reads you while you imagine you are reading it. I had been so afraid of getting it wrong that I never once noticed it was quietly, patiently, getting me right.

The women teach me a way of reading they call *lectio divina*, holy reading, which is only the ancient and unhurried practice of taking a few verses and sitting with them until they begin to give. You read it once to hear it. You read it again to find the one word that snags. You read it a third time and you stop performing and simply listen, and you let it ask you something for a change, instead of the other way around. It is the exact

opposite of the way I read everything else in my life, which is fast, and for use, and to extract. The psalm says, *your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path,* and I notice, the first time it truly lands, that a lamp to your feet is not a floodlight thrown out to the horizon. It shows you the next step. Only ever the next step. Which turns out to be precisely as much as I have ever actually been given, and precisely as much as faith has ever asked me to work with.

He says it himself, out in the wilderness, starving, with the tempter at his ear offering him bread: *one does not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God.* I had built an entire life on bread alone. On the visible, the edible, the provable, the things you can put on a résumé and a plate. And I had been quietly starving on a full stomach the whole time, in my well-lit hallway, with my arms crossed.

And then there is the parable that finally describes my own ground back to me, gently, the way a good doctor reads you your own chart. The sower goes out to sow, and the seed falls on four kinds of soil: the hard packed path where it cannot root and the birds take it, the rocky places where it springs up fast and green and then dies in the first real heat for having no depth, the thorns that let it grow and then choke it out with worry and the cares of the world and the lure of wealth, and at last the good soil, where it takes, and roots, and bears thirty and sixty and a hundredfold. I know that field by heart. I have been every inch of it. For years I am the hard path, packed down so tight by being fine that nothing on earth could get in. Then I am the thorns, the wants and the worries grown up so thick around the one green thread of hope that they strangle it before it can fruit. What those Saturdays do, what the love does, what the prayer does, is the slow agricultural work that nobody romanticizes and nobody posts about: they break up the hard ground. They pull the thorns out by the root. They do not hand me a harvest. They make me, at long last, into soil that something could actually grow in.

And the proof that it is working arrives in the body before I can account for it in the head, and the Scripture for it is, in the end, my favorite in the whole book. After the resurrection, two of them are walking the road to

Emmaus, gutted, certain the entire thing is over, and a stranger falls into step beside them and opens the Scriptures to them the whole long dusty way, and they do not even know it is him until he breaks the bread and vanishes from their sight. And then they turn to each other and say the line I think about every single Saturday morning of my life now: *were not our hearts burning within us while he talked to us on the road, while he opened the Scriptures to us?* That is it. That is the whole of it. Not a doctrine I can defend in an argument. A fire I can feel under my own ribs. Twelve women open the Scriptures to one another in a warm and holy room every Saturday, and my heart, the one I had kept on its short leash for so long, the one I had been ordered for years to turn down, burns within me. *So faith comes from hearing,* Paul writes, *and hearing through the word of Christ.* I came in unable so much as to open the book. I stayed because, read aloud in good company, the book began to open me.

PART SEVEN: OUR LADY

There is a statue I have been circling my whole life, and I did not understand that until I was forty, standing in the rain, but let me start at the beginning, because the beginning is a little girl running.

When I was small, my mother and my grandmother and I went to the cemetery the way some families go to the shore. While the two of them tended the graves they had come to tend, kneeling at the stones with their cloths and their flowers and their low women's voices, I was set loose, and what I did, every single time, with all that little-girl engine, was run loops around a statue of the Blessed Mother. She stood at the center of the older section, weather-softened, her painted blue gone chalky, her head bowed, her plaster hands open at her sides, her bare foot resting on a crescent moon and a serpent, the way they always carve her, the woman who crushes what we are most afraid of without ever once raising her voice. I did not know any of the theology. I only knew that she was calm in a way the adults were not, and that I could run and run around her and she would not tell me to settle down, and that being near her felt like being near the one grown-up at the party who is genuinely glad you exist.

That is where it started, and I want to be honest that for years I could not have told you why the Blessed Mother meant what she meant to me. The world, even the religious world, can be a little embarrassed about Mary, can treat devotion to her as something quaint, a sentimentality you are supposed to grow out of. I have grown the other direction. The older I get, the more I understand that she is the whole hinge of the thing, and that everything I was trying to learn about surrender, she did first, and did perfectly, at an age when I could barely surrender my seat on the bus.

Because here is what the angel asked her, a teenage girl in an occupied backwater, unmarried, with everything to lose and no possible way to explain it: would she carry God. Would she let her whole ordinary planned life be interrupted by something enormous and frightening and impossible to account for to the neighbors. And she asks one honest question, *how can this be*, which I love her for, because it means faith was never meant to be the absence of questions. And then she says the four hardest words in any language, the ones the whole world hangs on: *let it be done unto me according to your word. Fiat.* Let it be. That is the surrender I had been calling a spa word. That is the wheel, handed over, by a girl, completely. She did not know how the story ended. She did not get the outline in advance. She said yes to the whole terrifying invitation of her life with no guarantees at all, which is the only kind of yes that has ever meant anything.

And once she has said it, she does not shrink. She sings. The Magnificat, the song she sings when she goes to her cousin Elizabeth, is not the song of a frightened girl; it is a revolution set to music, *my soul magnifies the Lord, he has cast down the mighty from their thrones and lifted up the lowly, he has filled the hungry with good things.* The most surrendered woman who ever lived is also the boldest. That broke something open in me, because I had always thought surrender and strength were opposites, that to hand over the wheel was to go limp. She showed me they are the same muscle. You let go, and then you sing.

And she suffers, which is the part the sentimental version of her quietly edits out, and the exact part an empath needs most to know. When she brings the infant to the temple, the old man Simeon takes one look and tells her the thing no new mother ever wants spoken over her child: *this child is destined for the falling and the rising of many in Israel, and a sword will pierce your own soul too.* A sword. He says it to her face, at the very beginning, with the baby still in her arms. She loved more than anyone who has ever lived, and so she was pierced more deeply than anyone who has ever lived, because those two things have never once been separable, and no one who feels at full volume is ever honestly promised otherwise. And twice the Gospel stops the action just to tell us how she carried it all:

Mary treasured all these things, pondering them in her heart. She did not get it explained to her. She was not handed the outline in advance. She held it, every bit of it, the angel and the sword and the strange hard sayings of her own stranger child, and she pondered, which is the native work of a heart built with a screen door for skin. I had been told my whole life that feeling everything that deeply was a flaw to be managed down. The most blessed woman who ever drew breath did precisely that, on purpose, all the way to a cross, and the whole world has called her full of grace for two thousand years.

The Blessed Mother says exactly one more thing in all of Scripture after that, and it is the best advice anyone has ever given. At the wedding at Cana, when the wine runs out and the hosts are about to be humiliated, she does not fix it herself and she does not lecture. She simply turns to the servants, points them toward her son, and says, *do whatever he tells you.* Those are her last recorded words. Do whatever he tells you. A whole spirituality in five words, from a mother who spends the rest of eternity doing nothing but pointing away from herself and toward the one who loves us most. And then, at the very end, from the cross, in agony, he gives her to us, or us to her, *behold your mother,* so that none of us, not the orphaned, not the estranged, not the woman whose own father was a rumor on the far edge of a map, would ever have to be motherless again.

I learned the rosary at my grandmother's side, the beads moving one by one through her fingers and then through mine, and I did not understand for years that what she was handing me was not a chore but an inheritance. The rosary is Mary's prayer, but it is not really about Mary; it is about looking at her son through her eyes, decade after decade, the joyful and the sorrowful and the glorious, the whole human catalog of being born and suffering and rising, told on a string you can hold in the dark. It is the most maternal thing I know, repetitive the way a lullaby is repetitive, the way a heartbeat is repetitive, and somewhere in the middle of a decade the repetition stops being repetition and becomes a kind of shared

breathing, and you understand that you are not saying the prayer so much as being held inside it. My grandmother knew that. She prayed it like breathing. She is the reason I can.

So when I tell you, later, that I found her grave in the pouring rain directly across from a statue of the Blessed Mother, I need you to already know that this is not a coincidence I am dressing up. It is a circle I have been running my whole life, finally closing. The little girl, the loops, the calm woman with her foot on the moon. The grandmother who taught me to pray to her. And the grave, when it came, set down exactly where the running started. Some things you do not arrange. Some things are arranged for you, by the one who loves us most, through the mother he gave us from the cross, and your only job is to be paying enough attention to notice.

PART EIGHT: THE PEOPLE WHO HELD THE DOOR

Faith never once comes to me as a voice from a cloud. It comes wearing faces. The faces in that circle on Saturdays. And, underneath them, holding them up, the faces of the specific, stubborn people who refused, across years and even across death, to let go of me.

Start with my mother, because she is where I start. My mother knew me before I had a self to show anyone. Before the campaigns and the comebacks and the carefully maintained fine. Before the first follower and the first fear. I am a grown woman now, with a profession and strong opinions about font kerning and the morally correct way to load a dishwasher, and to her, none of that is the point and none of it ever was. There is a particular grace in being loved by someone who knew you before you built a personality to perform. She does not love the latest model. She never wanted the upgrade, never asked for the new features. She loves the original (scratches, dents, factory defects and all) and she has never once, in my whole life, asked me to revise it before she would accept it. When I think about what unconditional means, I do not reach for a definition. I reach for her face. She is the first proof I ever had that the love I would later find in that beautiful old church, my own parish, was real, because I had already had a small, lifelong, kitchen-table sample of it at home.

Then there is my father, and his is a harder story to tell, because for most of my life I did not have one to tell about him at all. My parents divorced when I was four. He moved to Arizona, and for twenty-five years he was less a father than a fact, a man at the far brown edge of the map of my life. I did not hate him. You cannot really hate a rumor.

What finally brings him back is the worst thing. In April of 2017, my best friend Rob dies, falling an inch off a ladder. You can write that sentence as many times as you like and it never once starts to make sense. An inch. A whole irreplaceable man, gone over the length of a thumb. My father sees it on Facebook, of all the absurd and ordinary places, and he sends me a message to say he is sorry for my loss. I sit with that little gray bubble glowing on my screen for a long, long time. And then I do the one thing about this entire story I will never have to regret. I decide I do not want to feel this again, this exact tearing, on the day he dies, with twenty-five years of unsaid things still locked in the dark room between us. So I write back.

And for the next year, we make up for all of it at once. We text and call every single day, like two schoolgirls passing notes under the desk, like we are trying to spend a whole quarter-century of words before some clock neither of us can see runs all the way down. He is a retired FDNY firefighter and a grandmaster Mason out there in the Arizona heat, and he becomes, of all the unlikely things on this green earth, my best friend. We make a plan. I will move out there. I will start over near him, finally, and we will take whatever years are left in the account and fill them right up to the brim.

And here is the regret I will carry into my own grave, so I am going to set it down plainly and let it stand without excuse. There is a parable about a man who finds a treasure buried in a field, and in his joy he goes and sells everything he has to buy that field, and another about a merchant who finds one pearl of such surpassing worth that he sells all his other pearls to have it. The whole of the gospel is in those two small stories: when the real thing finally appears, you let go of everything else to hold it. And I, who had finally found the pearl, who had finally been handed the father I had ached for my whole life, did not sell the field. I did not get on the plane. I stayed in New York and I guarded my boxes and my lease and my furniture as though any of it could keep a person warm, telling myself there was time, there was always going to be time. I kept all my lesser pearls. He died before I fixed it. I have spent this whole book talking about surrender,

about prying my fingers off the wheel, and the plain, unsoftened truth is that I learned the cost of refusing in the single most expensive way there is.

The night before he dies, we are on the phone for four hours. It is four in the morning, New York time, when I finally hang up, and I sit there in the dark afterward with the strangest, warmest thought arriving fully formed in my chest: *I actually have a father who loves me.* That night he tells me a story I have never heard, though it is really two stories, and it has taken me until now to understand they are the same one.

The first is about a boy. When my father was small, his uncle Norman, a tugboat captain, the kind of larger-than-life man who fills a doorway and a childhood both, told him he could fly, because he was wearing a Superman cape. And my father, who trusted him the way you trust the biggest, brightest grown-up in your world, believed him all the way, climbed up onto the roof, and jumped. He broke his nose on the ground his uncle had sworn he would never touch. He carried that small flattening on the bridge of his nose for the rest of his life, the first lesson, written into his own face, that the people who love you most can also be the ones who send you falling.

The second story is the one he had never told me, and it is the one I have not stopped thinking about since. Years before I was born, working a fire, he was overcome by carbon monoxide and dropped into a coma. And while he was under, in that place that is neither here nor gone, he saw Norman. The same uncle. The same man who had once talked him off a roof. Except this time Norman did not tell him to jump. This time, my father said, Norman put his hands on him and pushed him, hard, the other way, back down out of the light and into his own broken body, back into his life.

When my father finally came to, his mother was sitting at the bedside with terrible news she did not yet know how to give him: his uncle Norman had been killed that very day, in a tugboat fire, out on the water. And my father, barely surfaced, the machines still going, looked up at her before she could find the words and said the sentence that rearranges everything I thought I knew about the thin places: *"I know. I just saw him."*

Here is the part that lifts this clean out of the territory of family lore and into something I genuinely cannot explain away, though the modern, marketing, evidence-demanding part of my brain has spent years trying. There are newspaper articles. The fire, the boat, the hour Norman died, all of it set down in print by people who had no idea that across the city a man lay unconscious watching it happen. And the timing matches. The hour of the fire falls squarely inside the hours of my father's coma. He could not have known. There was no phone call he overheard, no nurse, no whispered hallway news that could have reached a man with no consciousness to reach. He simply went somewhere, while his body lay still as a stone, and met an uncle who was at that exact moment leaving this world, and was sent back with the knowing already sealed inside him before a single living soul had spoken it aloud. You can call one deathbed vision a trick of grief. It is a great deal harder to explain a vision that is dated, witnessed, and corroborated in the public record before the dreamer ever woke up to be told.

To my father, this was never a misfire of an oxygen-starved brain. It was the bedrock under everything else he believed: that the people who go on ahead of us are not gone, only out of sight, only in the next room with the door not quite latched, and that the veil between here and there is thinner, and far kinder, than we let ourselves hope. And I have turned the rest of it over more times than I can count, the symmetry of it, because it is too perfect to be only coincidence and too strange to be anything I could have invented. The very same man whose word once sent my father falling off a roof is the one who, at the last threshold, put his hands on him and refused to let him fall the rest of the way. The cape was not a lie after all. It just took a coma and a tragedy to come true. Norman did teach him to fly, in the end, in the only direction that ever finally matters, which was back. And I have come to believe that is the truest thing I know about the people who love us imperfectly, which is the only way anyone has ever loved anyone at all: the same hand that fails you when you are a child can be the hand that saves you when you are a man. The fall and the catch are not always two different people. Sometimes, if you are paying attention, and the communion of saints is doing its quiet and patient work, they are the same

love, still learning to aim. My father walked out of that hospital, and out of the rest of his life, unafraid of dying, because he had already been there once, and what he found waiting on the other side was family.

Paul writes to the Thessalonians, who are frightened sick about their dead, a single line that has held me up ever since I found it: *we do not want you to be uninformed, brothers and sisters, about those who have fallen asleep, so that you may not grieve as others do who have no hope.* Not, and I want to be careful here, *so that you may not grieve.* Grief is never the enemy of faith; grief is the receipt that proves you loved someone. So that you may not grieve *as those who have no hope.* There is a way of grieving that has a floor underneath it, and a way that has no floor at all and just keeps falling, and my father, dropped into a coma and sent back up out of it by a dead man's two hands, spent every remaining day of his life standing on that floor. *For now we see through a glass, darkly.* Paul writes elsewhere, in the most honest sentence ever written about faith, *but then face to face; now I know in part, but then I shall know fully, even as I have been fully known.* Through a glass, darkly. My father got, for a few unconscious hours, to set the dark glass down and look straight through. The rest of us only get the rumor of it: the 414 turning up on the clock, the heart burning on the Emmaus road, the corroborated newspaper, the strange thinness of the veil on certain gray afternoons. But the rumor, once you have trained yourself to listen for it, is steady enough to grieve on top of without falling through the floor.

And before we hang up, I confess something to him. I tell him I do not know what my purpose is. He does not even pause. He says, *"Well, ya got a great story, kid. Ya just need to tell it."*

The next day, the fourteenth of April, 2018, a massive heart attack takes him, all at once, with no warning and no goodbye beyond the one we did not know we had already said. The last whole thing my father ever hands me is an instruction that I am, at this exact moment, in the only way I know how, finally carrying out. You are holding it.

I see him now in numbers. He died on the fourteenth of the fourth, and ever since, 414 finds me everywhere: on clocks, on receipts, on license plates, in the corners of unrelated days, turning up so often it stops feeling like noticing and starts feeling like being greeted. There is another, 444, that belongs to my grandmother, and that one finds me too. People are welcome to call it coincidence if they need to. But I have stopped needing it to be. The angels, the saints, the ones who go ahead and stay near, they do not always speak in words; sometimes they speak in the small repeated signs of a paying-attention universe. I call them my angel numbers. I call them mail.

PART NINE: THE COMMUNION OF SAINTS

The other face faith wears, the one I have carried longest, belongs to my grandmother. Ju Ju. She passed last November, and all these months later I am still, sentence by sentence, learning how to build a clause with her inside the past tense. It does not fit. My mouth will not make the shape.

Her faith was the quiet kind: never performed, only lived, threaded so finely through the ordinary hours of her days that after a while you stopped seeing the thread at all and saw only the warmth it was holding together. She did not argue anyone into anything. She just prayed, every day, like Saint Monica, who wept and prayed for her wayward son Augustine for thirty years until he became the man whose restless sentence I quote in this very book, who would not have been a saint if his mother had not refused, decade after decade, to stop asking. That is the kind of faith my grandmother had. The kind that works underground, on other people's behalf, for years, with no applause and no evidence, and changes the course of lives that will never quite know they were carried. She was also the first person on this whole earth to believe in my writing, back when there was nothing yet to believe in, when it was all just promise and bad first drafts and a girl who felt too much. She told me, more than once, looking right into me, that I was a great writer. She did not say it the way you offer a comfort to a child. She said it the way you state a fact about the weather out the window. This book exists because of her. And she will never get to hold it. I have to hold both of those at once, and some days I can, and some days I cannot.

I told you about the cemetery and the statue and the little girl running loops. Here is where the circle closes. The grave that holds Ju Ju now sits directly across from that same statue of the Blessed Mother, the calm woman with her foot on the moon. I did not arrange that. I do not know who did. It was pouring the day I went looking for her, the cemetery

unfolding like a small flooded city, row after gray row, the grass gone to standing water, the sky the exact color of the stones, and I went through it in the rain with the water running down my face until I genuinely could not tell anymore which of it was the sky and which of it was me. And somewhere in all that water I found her name. Across from the Blessed Mother. Right where the running started, forty years and a whole lifetime of fear ago.

I remember her last hours with a clarity that frightens me a little. We prayed the rosary. I can still feel the whole rhythm of it living in my hands, the smooth cool beads moving one by one through my fingers, the same beads, the same prayer she first set into those fingers when they were small enough to need showing. I held her hand in both of mine, and we prayed, and I will spend the rest of my life grateful beyond saying that the last language between us was that one. The oldest one. The first one she ever taught me. We ended exactly where we began, which is, I am learning, how the truest things tend to end.

There is an old, stubborn idea in my church called the communion of saints, the notion that everyone who has ever loved you, the living and the long gone alike, belongs to one single body, and that they go on holding you up together, across the whole distance of time, hand over hand over hand. The saints in their niches in that old church are not decorations. They are family, the ones who already made it through, who ran their own eleven minutes in their own rain and went up the steps anyway, and who now, the doctrine says, can be asked, the way you would ask any older relative who loves you to keep you in their prayers. I am not theologian enough to defend the mechanics of it in an argument. But I am experienced enough now to know it in my own chest. My father is in that communion. My grandmother is in it. Rob is in it. The cloud of witnesses the letter to the Hebrews talks about, the great crowd in the stands cheering on the ones still running, that is not a metaphor to me anymore. And here is what those Saturdays taught me that no doctrine had managed to: so are the living. The dozen women in the circle hold me up

here and now, every bit as surely as the saints hold me up from their niches. I feel the grip of it most on Saturdays, and at 4:14, and at 4:44, and in the rain, and on my knees with the beads going through my fingers.

And I mean Biggie too, my dog, asleep through every word of this, possibly a minor angel, possibly just a dog, and I get less convinced by the year that there is any difference. He heals me daily by needing his dinner, reliably and indignantly, at five, which is its own small liturgy, its own bell calling me back from whatever spiral to the plain holy duty of feeding something that loves me.

PART TEN: PEOPLE ARE PEWS TOO

I want to tell you about the pews, because I sat in them for the better part of forty years before I understood what they were for.

A pew is the most humble thing in a beautiful building. While the windows blaze and the vault soars and the altar gleams, the pew just sits there along the floor, plain and dark and worn, asking for nothing, drawing no eye. And yet it is doing the one indispensable thing. It is holding you up. It takes your whole tired weight without comment, so that your body is free to do the single thing you came in to do, which is to kneel, and to rise, and to pray. The wood under my hands in that old church has been rubbed smooth and golden by a hundred years of other people's hands, other people's grief, other people's white-knuckled hope, generations of the frightened and the grateful who sat exactly where I sit and are gone now, and the pew holds me the way it held them, without ever once needing to be thanked.

And somewhere in my second or third year of Saturdays, kneeling in a pew that had outlived everyone who built it, I understood the thing this whole book has been circling. People are pews too. The quiet structure underneath. The plain, unglamorous, load-bearing presence that takes your weight on the days your own legs will not, and asks for nothing in return, and frees you to keep facing forward. The dozen women in the circle are pews. My mother is a pew, and has been since before I could walk. Ju Ju was a pew, and is one still, from the far side of the veil. The saints in their niches are pews. My father, who could not hold me up the way he wanted to in life, holds me up now in numbers on a clock.

Scripture is full of pews, once you have the eyes for them. When Moses stood on the hill above the battle and everything turned on whether he could keep his arms raised, and his arms grew heavy, as any human arms

will, Aaron and Hur did not lecture him about endurance. They rolled a stone under him so he could sit, and then they stood on either side and held his arms up for him, one on each side, until the sun went down and the day was won. That is the whole of it. That is a pew with a face. And when the four friends could not get their paralyzed friend through the crowd to be healed, they carried him up onto the roof and tore the roof open and lowered him down on his mat into the room below, and the gospel says that Jesus, seeing their faith, the faith of the friends, the faith of the ones doing the carrying, healed the man who could not get himself in. Even the Lord, at the very end, under the weight of the cross, let them pull Simon of Cyrene out of the crowd to carry it when he could no longer carry it alone. If the Son of God accepted a pew on the worst road of his life, I can surely stop pretending I was ever meant to carry mine by myself.

Bear one another's burdens, Paul writes, *and so fulfill the law of Christ.* *Two are better than one,* says the Preacher in Ecclesiastes, *because if either of them falls, the one will lift up the other; but woe to one who is alone and falls and does not have another to help.* I had built an entire life on being the one who was alone and did not fall. The strong one. The one who held everyone else up and would have died, did nearly die, before letting anyone hold up me. I had it exactly backward. The strength was never in carrying it alone. The strength was in finally, at long last, letting myself be carried.

He promised it would work exactly this way, in the smallest gathering he could think to name. *For where two or three are gathered in my name,* he says, *there am I among them.* Not where two or three thousand fill a stadium with the lights and the band. Not where the famous preacher works the stage. Two or three. A dozen women and a circle of folding chairs clears that bar with nine to spare. I used to assume God lived in the grand parts of the building, up in the unreachable vault, behind the altar, inside the blazing windows, in all the places built on purpose to make a person feel small. And he is there, surely. But he told us plainly where else to look for him, and it is lower down, and far closer in: in the small gathered group, in the two or three, in the pew-level company of a few ordinary

people who showed up in his name on a Saturday morning and went on to save one another's lives, most of them without ever quite realizing that was what they were doing.

I used to believe I was self-made. I said it from podiums like it was a virtue. It was a lie, the kind we tell from podiums precisely because it sounds so good out loud. I am held up, in every single moment, by a hundred small unglamorous hands. Some of them belong to saints in plaster niches. Some of them stopped being attached to anyone breathing years ago, and they hold me anyway. Some of them are folded right now around a rosary, praying for a granddaughter from the far side of the veil. And some of them texted me back this morning.

PART ELEVEN: THE LATEST MODEL

So. Here we are. Who am I now.

Not the woman who stood at the bottom of the steps for eleven minutes, terrified of a lit and entirely harmless door. Not quite her anymore. And yet (and this is the part I never once saw coming) also, somehow, completely her.

I had assumed healing would turn me into someone else. A different woman. An upgrade so total and so clean that I would lose the old one entirely in the swap, and good riddance. I was almost looking forward to it, the way you look forward to the last page of a chapter you have hated.

Good riddance to her, I thought. The scared one. The fine one. The one out on the sidewalk in the rain with her hands going numb around a folding bulletin.

That is not what happens. What happens is harder to fit on a book jacket and a thousand times truer to live inside. I do not become someone else. I become her again, the woman I had been long before fear talked me, slowly and so reasonably, into making myself smaller and quieter and easier to carry around. The poet. The loud one. The empath who feels everything at a volume the world keeps calling a malfunction, and who has finally decided that the volume was never the bug. The volume was the gift the entire time. I get her back. Same soul. Same wiring. The latest model.

No one puts new wine into old wineskins, the Lord warns, *or the skins burst and the wine is spilled; new wine is put into fresh wineskins, and so both are preserved.* For most of my life I read that as a story about replacement. Out with the old, in with the new. Now I read it as a story about capacity, and it stops my breath every time. You do not get a brand-new self handed to you, clean and shrink-wrapped, at the door. You get a self finally

grown big enough, and supple enough, and soft enough, to hold, without bursting, everything that was always already fermenting and alive inside you.

There is a verse everyone quotes about exactly this, and for years I heard it as an eviction notice served on the only self I had: *if anyone is in Christ, there is a new creation; the old has passed away, behold, the new has come.* The old has passed away. For a long time that sounded to me like a threat. Now I hear the stress fall in a different place entirely. Not a new *person*, swapped in for the disappointing old one. A new *creation*, which is the same old material made new, the way a fallow field is not replaced but restored, the way Lazarus is not exchanged for a healthier and less complicated man but called, by his own name, the same man, back out of his own tomb. Isaiah has God say, *behold, I am doing a new thing; now it springs forth, do you not perceive it? I will make a way in the wilderness and rivers in the desert.* A way in the wilderness. Not a different, nicer wilderness somewhere else. A way through the very one you are already standing in. And Paul, who had more past to live down than almost anyone, names the thing I am still, daily, learning how to do: *forgetting what lies behind and straining forward to what lies ahead, I press on toward the goal.* Not erasing what lies behind. Forgetting it the way you finally stop gripping the railing once your own feet are steady under you, so that your hands, at long last, are free for whatever comes next.

That is what I mean by the word. Rebecoming is not erasing who you were. It is recovering her. It is finding her right where you left her, in the dark, at the bottom of the steps, arms crossed in the corner, and at long last building her a bigger room. The resurrection, stripped all the way down to the frame, is the most audacious reinvention story ever told, and we have let the stigma convince us it is a story for a certain kind of person. It is not. It is the same person who went into the tomb who comes back out. The same wounds, even, still open enough to put a hand into, the way doubting Thomas put his into the risen Lord's and stopped doubting on the spot. And yet more alive than before. That is the model I am working from. Not a

clean swap. Not a factory reset. A return. A coming-back. With every scar deliberately, defiantly left in, because the scars were never the damage.

The scars are the proof.

I think, at the end, about the woman at the well, because she is the whole mission in a single afternoon, and I did not understand that until I had lived it. She is the one everybody had written off. The wrong kind of woman, with the wrong kind of history, coming to draw water at noon, in the worst of the heat, specifically so she would not have to face the other women at the cooler hours. The outsider's outsider. And she is the one, her, not the certain ones, not the qualified ones, not the row of judges I had invented and feared, who meets him at the well, and is seen all the way to the bottom, and drops her water jar and runs back into the town and tells everyone. She becomes the first evangelist, the first to spread the word, and Scripture says many believed because of her testimony. The least likely person in the story carries it the farthest. I read that now and I think: of course. Of course it is her. It is the only way the thing has ever traveled, hand to hand, outsider to outsider, one un-grayed woman dropping her jar and running back to tell the next one that the water is real, and that it is living, and that you will never be thirsty in the old way again.

I am still afraid sometimes. I want to be honest about that, here at the end, because every book that swears the fear leaves for good is selling the same lie the algorithm sells, only now with a cross on the cover and a higher price at the register. The fear still comes around. It still knocks at two in the morning. The only difference now, and it is the difference that remade my entire life, is that it no longer controls the thermostat. It knocks, and I open the door, and I pull out a chair and let it sit and say its whole anxious piece, and then I pray, and then I hope, and then, in the words of the suffering saint, I do not worry. And then it goes. It does not get to stay the night anymore. That bed is mine, and the room around it is full now: full of friends, full of saints, full of the living and the dead who love me, full, at long last, of hope I no longer have to ration.

I traded fear for faith. Not, in the end, by getting rid of the fear, but by growing, slowly and with an enormous and humbling amount of help, bigger than it. By learning, one ordinary Saturday morning at a time, to peel my own fingers off the wheel and to say, with a teenage girl in Nazareth, *let it be done.* By learning the novenas, the long faithful nine-day asking of the persistent widow. By building a self out of a scanned QR code and an angel's arms in a doorway and a stranger's ink-crowded margins and a grandmother's worn rosary and a father's last four-hour phone call and an unbothered dog and a Blessed Mother with her foot on the moon and a dozen women who held the door and then refused to let me leave, a self finally roomy enough to hold all that fear and keep walking forward anyway, in good company, in the light, in the company of the one who loves us most.

The last thing my father ever gave me was a sentence. *You got a great story, kid, you just need to tell it.* I could not find my purpose the night he asked me for it. I have come to believe it was hiding inside his answer the whole time. It was never a title. Never a job. It was just this: telling the truth out loud until it reaches whoever needs it next. Until it walks down the steps to the person standing at the bottom in the rain.

So let me walk down to you, since that is the whole job. If you are standing where I stood, at the bottom of some set of steps, in some kind of weather, with a reasonable speech ready and a costume of good reasons buttoned to the chin and a door that feels much farther than forty feet, hear me. Somebody told you that room was not for you. Somebody told you what kind of woman walks through it, and let you believe you were not her. That was the lie. I cannot walk up the steps for you; that part has only ever had one set of feet. But I can tell you, from the inside, exactly what is on the other side of that door: not certainty, not a clean fix, not a row of judges. A beautiful old church with the light coming through colored glass. A rack of candles holding other people's hope. A chair with your name on it. Friendships you have stopped believing get issued to someone your age. A way of praying that turns the lights back on. A mother who has been waiting for you since before you were born. And a leader who will cross the

floor like the dawn and put her arms around you before you have even said your name. Find your version of the steps. Stand at the bottom as long as you need to. And then, go up anyway. You are already late for people who are going to love you.

I am still a draft. You caught me mid-revision; you can probably see the pencil marks. I am still a long way off, still on the road, still, most mornings, a little afraid. But I get up. I say my prayers. I scan the code, I climb the steps, I walk in. And I have finally, finally stopped pretending I am doing any of it alone.

♡ MK

REBECOMING: THE LATEST MODEL

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